

Technical Report Writing (TRW)

Chapter No 6
(Techniques)

Summarizing

Chapter in a Nutshell

- What is a summary
- What is an abstract
- Audiences of summaries and abstracts
- How to plan a summary?
- Choose an organization
- How to write a summary?

What is a summary

- A summary is a restatement of another document and it restates major findings or main information of the document, article, passage or a report. Readers may use summaries to decide whether to read the entire (document, article, passage or report) or to get the gist of it without reading it or to preview it before reading it. It is a synopsis or a summation of the document.
- The ability to construct and present concise or short versions of long documents is not only helpful for your audience but also essential. You will often summarize your own written documents and also those written by others.

What is an abstract

Summarizing or abstracting; both the terms are nearly synonymous and these are fundamental to technical writing. An abstract is generally a short version of a journal article. There are two kinds of abstracts;

Indicative Abstract: It lists the documents topics.

Informative Abstract: It presents the short versions of the document's qualitative and quantitative information.

On the whole, an abstract usually mentions the document's purpose, scope, methodologies, results and conclusions.

Audiences of summaries and abstracts

- Summaries and abstracts serve similar functions, allowing readers to discover the gist of the report, an article or a document, without actually reading the entire document.
- Since we write a summary or an abstract to enable an executive officer/decision maker/ administrator, we call it as executive summary.
- Summary or abstract is of a report or document, so we need to have a document first. Regarding your own written document, first complete the document and then write summary or abstract at the end. Hence, a summary or abstract is written last, but placed first, before a report.

How to plan or prepare for a summary?

- The basic summarizing strategy includes two activities:

1. Read to find the main terms and concepts.

What are the main divisions of the document?

What are the key statements?

Which sentences express the overall purpose of the document?

Which sentences tell the main ideas of each paragraph?

Which details support the main ideas?

What are the key terms and words that are repeated or emphasized?

Decide how much detail to include?

- To decide how much detail to include, consider your audience's need.
- The general rule is to be as complete as your readers require.

(Requirement and need of the audience)

Choose an organization

- The two main strategies for organizing a summary are:
- Proportional reduction
- Main point followed by support

How to write a summary?

- Use the usual form by focusing on the following characteristics:
- Use the verbs in the active voice.
- Use the present tense. (In English, there are four present tenses: simple present, present perfect, present continuous, and present perfect continuous.)
- Do not use terms, abbreviations or symbols unfamiliar to the readers.
- Do not give opinions or evaluative comments. (report facts without bias)
- Prefer to focus on the main information and bypass supporting information.
- Prefer to use the 3rd person pronouns.
- Follow the instructions of the previous chapters (use the top-down method and all points discussed in chapter 4, regarding style)
- Write the first draft and edit it by ensuring the above to make a final copy.